## Richard Dawkins



Richard Dawkins was born in Kenya to British parents. After the family returned to the UK, became very interested the natural world and studied zoology at Oxford University. While there, he was tutored by Nobel Prize-winner Niko Tinbergen, a pioneer of animal behavior studies. After a brief period at the University of California at Berkeley, Dawkins returned to Oxford to lecture in zoology.

Dawkins is best known for his book *The Selfish Gene*, in which he argues that the gene is the principal unit of selection in evolution. His theory later triggered a series of fierce debates with Stephen Jay Gould and other evolutionary biologists. Dawkins is also known as a strong advocate of atheism and feminism, although he has been criticized by some for his views on Islam.

### Key works

**1976** *The Selfish Gene*

**1982** *The Extended Phenotype*

**1986** *The Blind Watchmaker*

**2006** *The God Delusion*

**2009** *The Greatest Show*

*on Earth: The Evidence for Evolution*

**See also:** Evolution by natural selection • The rules of heredity • The role of DNA • Mutualisms